THE 90-DAY CLINICAL LICENSING EXAM STUDY PLAN



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Free sample

THE 90-DAY CLINICAL LICENSING EXAM STUDY PLAN
A structured, independent preparation schedule for the 2026 ASWB Clinical (LCSW) examination

This sample contains the contents, the opening of the book and one full chapter ("Chapter 3. Reading a score report without over-reading it"), exactly as they appear in the full book. The full book has 105 pages. Page numbers in the contents refer to the full book.

Get the full book:

https://thevelvetfoundry.gumroad.com/l/aswb-clinical-90-day-study-plan

Independent guide. Not affiliated with, endorsed by or approved by ASWB. Contains no examination questions. No pass is promised.

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How to use this book

This is not a book about social work. It is a book about ninety days.

This book is a study plan for the Clinical (LCSW) licensing examination for social workers, one of the Social Work Licensing Examinations set by the Association of Social Work Boards (ASWB). "Clinical" is the name of ASWB's examination category for clinical social work practice. This is not a medical or nursing examination.

Its main reader has just sat the Clinical examination and not passed, so the plan is built around the ninety-day retake window. If you have just sat the Clinical examination and not passed, you have been handed three things: a score report, a waiting period, and a content outline you are free to download. What nobody has handed you is a plan — a decision about what you will study on the fourteenth of next month, and how you will know by then whether it is working.

That is the whole job of this book. Every chapter exists to get you to a calendar with ninety days filled in, and to keep you on it when a week goes wrong.

If this is your first attempt. The plan works the same way if you have not sat the examination before: choose your test date and count back ninety days to day 1. The parts written for a retake (the score report in chapter 3, the waiting rule in chapter 1 and the "if you did not pass" section of chapter 22) will not apply to you yet.

Read it in this order

Read Part I (chapters 1 to 4) before you plan anything. It is short, and it covers the four things that change how you should plan: what the waiting rule actually says, what changed about the examination in 2026, what your score report can and cannot tell you, and the six ways preparation usually fails.

Then work through Part II (chapters 5 to 8) with a calendar open. By the end of chapter 8 you will have a written plan. Parts III (chapters 9 to 13) and IV (chapters 14 to 19) are the daily reference you come back to during the ninety days. Part V (chapters 20 to 22) covers logistics, examination day and what comes after. If you may qualify for a waiver of the waiting period, read chapter 20 in week one; otherwise you can leave Part V until week ten.

What you need before you start

A calendar you actually look at. A notebook or a plain document for your own questions. The examination guidebook published by ASWB, which is free and contains the content outline and reference list for your examination. Nothing else is required. You do not need to buy anything to follow this plan, including anything from us beyond this book.

A word about effort

The plan in this book assumes about ten to twelve hours of study a week. That is a deliberate choice. Plans that assume twenty-five hours a week look impressive and collapse in nine days, usually taking the candidate's confidence with them. If you have more time, the book tells you where extra hours actually help, which is often not where the extra hours go.

One thing to get straight now

Not passing once does not mean you are not capable of this. You hold the degree and you have the supervised hours. ASWB's own guidebook says that most test-takers find preparation involves reviewing areas of practice they might not use frequently, rather than learning something completely unfamiliar (guidebook, p. 29). The gap is usually coverage and recall under time pressure, and both of those are scheduling problems. Scheduling problems are solvable, which is the good news in this book.

Important: what this book is and is not

Please read this chapter. It is here for your protection as much as ours.

Not affiliated with ASWB. This book is an independent study-planning guide published by The Velvet Foundry. It is not affiliated with, endorsed by, approved by, sponsored by or connected to the Association of Social Work Boards (ASWB), Pearson VUE, or any social work licensing board. "ASWB" and the names of its examinations are used here only to identify the examination this plan is designed for.

ASWB makes this point itself, and it is worth knowing. Its published guidebook warns candidates that some private companies give the impression they are affiliated with or approved by ASWB, and states plainly that ASWB has no relationship with any test preparation company or course (guidebook, p. 30). Treat any product that hints otherwise — including any product that hints it knows what is on the paper — with suspicion. That includes ours, which is why we are telling you.

Which examination this is. This book is about the Clinical (LCSW) examination, the ASWB examination category for clinical social work licensure. ASWB's guidebook describes the Clinical category as the practice of clinical social work requiring the application of specialized clinical knowledge and advanced clinical skills (guidebook, p. 4). It is a licensing examination for social workers, not a medical examination, and nothing in this book is medical advice.

This book contains no examination questions. It contains no examination material of any kind, no reconstructed items, and nothing described as representative of what you will be asked. Every scenario in it was written for this book to demonstrate a method of reasoning. Each one is labelled as such. None is drawn from any examination.

This is not modesty. Examination content is confidential and protected by copyright and other laws, and the confidentiality agreement you signed binds you too: you agree not to share examination content with others, including in study groups, in person, by email or on internet forums and social media (guidebook, p. 19). ASWB's guidebook states that it monitors online information sources and has taken legal steps against people who violate test security, and that people who violate confidentiality can face serious criminal and administrative repercussions (guidebook, p. 30). If you come across a forum, a file or a seller offering you the questions, walking away from it protects your licence.

No guarantee. Passing a licensing examination depends on your own knowledge, preparation and performance on the day. This book provides a study structure and nothing more. It cannot and does not guarantee any examination result. We make no claim about pass rates, and you should distrust anyone who does.

Verify the rules yourself. Examination format, fees, policies, content outlines and waiting rules are set by ASWB and by your own licensing board, and they change — as the 2026 format change demonstrates. The statements in this book about the examination were checked against ASWB's published material on 7 November 2026: the 08/2026 edition of the ASWB Examination Guidebook and several pages on aswb.org. The book names ASWB as the source of each rule, and the sources section at the end lists the documents and pages that were opened. Before you rely on any of it, confirm it against ASWB's current published material and with your own board. Where this book and ASWB disagree, ASWB is right.

Not professional advice. Nothing here is clinical, legal or licensure advice.

What this book deliberately does not do

It does not teach you clinical content. There is no material here on diagnosis, treatment selection, pharmacology or intervention technique.

That is a deliberate limit and you deserve the reason. This book is published by a small independent publisher. We are competent at designing study schedules, retrieval practice and pacing, and we are not licensed clinical social workers. A licensing examination is the gate to a profession where being wrong has consequences for other people, and we are not willing to write clinical teaching material for it and let you mistake it for authority.

So we have written the part we can stand behind. For clinical content, work from the reference list in ASWB's guidebook — the texts named there, your own graduate course material, and the practice you already have. Chapter 7 covers how to assemble that. This book organises your revision of those sources. It does not try to replace them.

CHAPTER 1

The 90-day window, and what the rule actually says

You already know there is a wait. The details are easier to miss, and they change how you plan.

The rule

ASWB policy states that candidates must wait 90 days between examination attempts (ASWB page "If you fail the exam"; the guidebook, p. 20, says to "wait 90 days before your next testing appointment").

Three practical consequences:

You cannot test early just because you feel ready. The ninety days are not a recommendation. Plan for the full window; this book assumes it.

ASWB's published material states no cap on attempts of its own, but some licensing boards limit how many times an applicant may take the examination. ASWB says so (guidebook, p. 20) and tells candidates to contact its Candidate Services Center to find out whether their board's approval is needed. Do this in week one. If your board limits attempts, you need to know the number before you decide how to use these ninety days, because it changes how conservative you should be about booking the next date.

You are also advised to wait before re-registering. ASWB's page "If you fail the exam" advises waiting seven to ten days after your last exam before registering again, and the examination fee is due at registration. For the Clinical examination that fee is US$260. Chapter 20 covers the sequence.

The waiver, and when it matters

There is an exception, and it is narrower than rumour suggests. You may request a waiver of the waiting period if your most recent score was within ten correct answers of the passing score (the wording on ASWB's waiver page; the guidebook says "within 10 points"), if your board permits waivers, and if you submit the request online through ASWBCentral. You must wait at least one day (24 hours) after the examination before submitting. ASWB's waiver page adds that California and North Dakota do not permit 90-day waivers and that no more than two waivers may be used in twelve months for any one examination category. Your new test date must still be at least ninety days out unless the waiver is granted.

If you are in that band, read chapter 20 in week one rather than week ten, because it changes your timetable. ASWB also advises not registering until a requested waiver has been granted or denied.

But here is the honest counsel: being within ten answers of passing means you were close, not that you were unlucky. The gap that keeps a candidate ten answers short is usually thin coverage of one area or slow pacing, and both take weeks, not days, to shift. If a waiver gets you a date in six weeks, run the plan in this book compressed — chapter 19 explains how — but do not take the early date simply because it is available.

Why ninety days is a good length

You may not feel grateful for the wait. From a study-design point of view it is close to ideal.

Ninety days is long enough for spaced repetition to work: material you study in week two can be retested in week three, week five and week eight, which is what moves it into durable recall. It is also long enough to rehearse a four-hour paper more than once without exhausting yourself. And it is short enough to hold a plan in view, which a six-month runway is not.

The risk in ninety days is not that it is too short. It is that weeks one to six feel unhurried, nothing is scheduled, and the work compresses into the last fortnight — where it does the least good. The plan in this book front-loads coverage for exactly that reason.

Set your dates now

Before you read on, write down three dates: today, your earliest permitted test date, and the date ninety days from today. If your board or a waiver changes the middle one, write that down too. Count carefully: if day 1 of the plan is the day after your last attempt, day 90 falls 89 days after it. ASWB's published pages say "90 days" without saying how the days are counted, so confirm your earliest permitted test date with ASWB's Candidate Services Center and, if in doubt, put day 90 a few days later.

Everything in Parts II and III is numbered relative to day 1, so you can map it onto any start date. Do not skip this. A plan without dates is a wish.

CHAPTER 3

Reading a score report without over-reading it

Your score report is evidence. It is also a Rorschach test, and it is easy to build a whole study plan on a reading it cannot support. This chapter is about extracting the signal and stopping there.

What the report gives you

ASWB reports results as pass or fail, with the number of questions needed to pass and the number you answered correctly. If you do not pass, the unofficial score report also shows the number you answered correctly and the total number of questions in each content area (guidebook, p. 18). You learn roughly how you performed across the broad areas. You do not learn which questions you got wrong, or why.

That is how the report works: ASWB's guidebook says you will not be able to review your exam (p. 19), and examination content is confidential.

What you can legitimately conclude

One: your weakest area is probably genuinely weaker. Area-level feedback across roughly thirty-five to forty questions is a reasonable signal. If Values and Ethics came out lowest, treat that as real.

Two: a near-miss overall means coverage, not capability. If you were close, you do not need to relearn the profession. You need the areas you skimmed, and you need pacing.

Three: a wide spread between areas tells you about your preparation, not your ability. A candidate strong in intervention and weak in ethics has usually studied what they enjoy. That is the most fixable pattern in this book.

What you cannot conclude

You cannot rank the three areas finely. The difference between your second and third area may be two questions, which is noise. Do not build a plan that treats a two-question gap as a finding.

You cannot diagnose a sub-topic. The report does not tell you that you are weak on informed consent specifically. If you find yourself concluding something that precise, you are inventing it.

You cannot conclude you were unlucky. Possibly you were. It is also the least useful available explanation, because nothing follows from it. Plan as though the result reflected your preparation, because that is the only reading you can act on.

You cannot conclude the paper was unfair. It may have felt that way; that feeling is common, and it is a poor guide.

How to use it in one page

In your notebook, write three lines — one per content area — and against each put:

1. Your area-level result as reported, in ASWB's own words. Not your interpretation.
2. Your own confidence, 1 to 5, recorded *before* you looked at the report. If you did not record it, do it now from memory of how the paper felt, and mark that it is retrospective.

3. One sentence on what you actually did to prepare that area last time: hours, materials, and whether you ever tested yourself on it rather than reading it.

That third line is the one that pays. Look for an area you only ever read about and never once tested yourself on. If you find one, you have found something more useful than any score breakdown.

Then put it away

Seriously. Photograph the page, close the report, and do not reopen it before day 60. It has given you everything it has, and read repeatedly it becomes a way of feeling bad rather than a way of planning. The coverage map you build in chapter 18 is a better instrument from here on, because it reflects what you have done this time.